

AI Implementation and Strategies

WHY THIS MODULE MATTERS

Governance structures are only as good as the delivery habits that carry them. This module turns everything so far into a practical implementation plan your organisation can actually run day to day.

7.1 From Policy to Practice

A governance framework only has value once it is embedded in the routines that teams already follow. This module focuses on implementation: how to translate the structures introduced in Modules 5 and 6 into a delivery pipeline without treating responsible AI as a separate, bolt-on process that teams route around under deadline pressure.

7.2 Embedding Governance in the Development Lifecycle

Rather than adding a single ethics review at the end of a project, mature organisations distribute lightweight checkpoints across the lifecycle, each matched to the decisions being made at that stage.

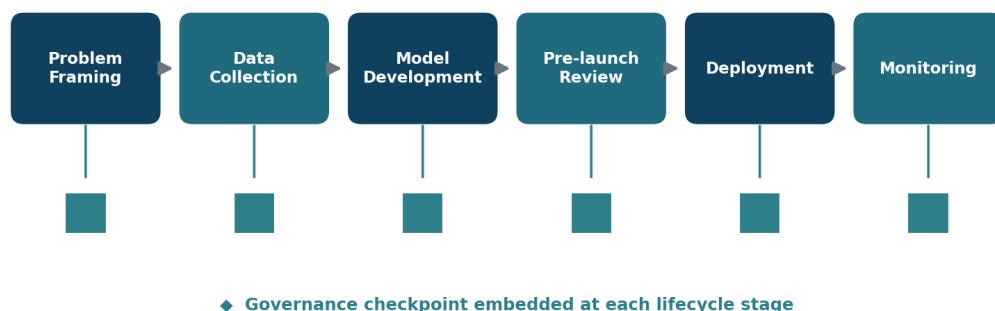


Figure 7.1 — Governance checkpoints distributed across the delivery pipeline, rather than concentrated in a single end-of-project review.

- **Problem framing** — document the intended use, out-of-scope uses, and the population the system will affect, before data collection begins.
- **Data collection and preparation** — assess representativeness of the training data relative to the deployment population, and check lawful basis and DPIA requirements.
- **Model development** — evaluate performance across relevant subgroups, not only in aggregate, and document trade-offs explicitly.
- **Pre-launch review** — apply the risk-tiered review appropriate to the system's classification, with sign-off from a named accountable owner.
- **Deployment** — launch with monitoring and an appeals channel active from day one, not added retroactively.
- **Post-deployment monitoring** — track outcome metrics on a defined cadence and set thresholds that trigger review.

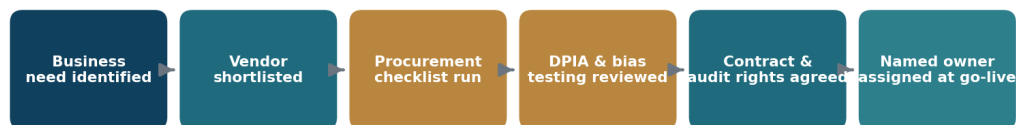
7.3 Building Organisational Capability

Tools and checklists are necessary but not sufficient. Sustained implementation depends on people across the organisation having enough shared literacy to use those tools well, and on incentives that reward raising a concern rather than quietly absorbing risk to hit a deadline.

- **Shared vocabulary** — ensure engineering, product, legal and leadership use consistent definitions for terms like “high-risk system” or “material incident”, so escalation is not lost in translation.
- **Escalation without penalty** — teams need confidence that flagging a concern will be treated as diligence, not as a delay to be worked around.
- **Executive sponsorship** — governance structures that lack visible support from leadership tend to be the first casualty of a tight deadline.
- **Iterative tooling** — start with lightweight templates and checklists, then refine them based on what teams actually use, rather than designing an exhaustive framework up front that no one adopts.

7.4 Procurement and Third-Party AI

Many UK organisations adopt AI primarily by buying it rather than building it. Procurement is therefore a critical, and frequently under-used, governance checkpoint. Before signing a contract for an AI-enabled product, a buyer should be able to answer: what data does this vendor process and where; what lawful basis and safeguards does the vendor rely on; can the vendor explain, at a level suitable for the buyer's own transparency obligations, how the system reaches its outputs; and what contractual audit or assurance rights does the buyer retain.



Template 5 (Procurement Checklist) is completed before contract sign-off

Figure 7.2 — The AI procurement process, with the checklist and DPIA/bias review sitting before contract sign-off, not after.

7.5 Common Implementation Pitfalls

- Treating governance as a one-time certification rather than an ongoing monitoring commitment.

- Placing all responsibility on a single central team, which becomes a bottleneck and a single point of failure.
- Designing review processes without input from the engineering teams who will use them, producing friction without added safety.
- Measuring governance success by the number of reviews completed rather than the outcomes those reviews actually changed.
- Assuming a third-party AI vendor's own compliance claims remove the buyer's own accountability under UK GDPR — as a controller or joint controller, the buying organisation typically retains its own obligations.

IN PRACTICE

A mid-sized UK healthcare technology company introduces a lightweight “AI intake form” that any team completes before starting a new AI-enabled feature. The form routes automatically to a risk tier and flags whether a DPIA is likely required; low-risk projects proceed immediately, while higher-risk projects are scheduled for a short review with a cross-functional panel. Within two quarters, most teams complete the form without prompting because it adds less friction than the informal escalation process it replaced.

7.6 Staffing and Agency Due Diligence

Implementation does not stop at process design; it depends on the people executing that process being properly briefed, vetted and supported — and for many AI-adjacent and data centre operations roles, those people are supplied by a recruitment agency rather than employed directly. This creates a specific, practical implementation task that is easy to overlook: making sure governance travels with the worker, not just with the employer.

- Pre-placement briefing** — agencies placing staff into data centre, security or AI-adjacent operational roles should brief candidates on the client's governance expectations before day one, not rely on the client's own induction to cover it from a standing start.
- Right-to-escalate clauses** — contracts between a recruitment agency, its client and the worker should make explicit that the worker can escalate a safety, security or ethics concern through the client's channels, without needing to route it through the agency first.
- Continuity of screening** — vetting standards such as BS 7858, introduced in Module 5, should be portable and auditable across placements, rather than repeated inconsistently by each new client.
- Feedback into governance review** — agencies and clients should have a mechanism for frontline operational staff — who are often the first to notice a system behaving unexpectedly — to feed observations back into the governance structures from Module 5, not just into their own line manager informally.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Governance should be distributed across the development lifecycle, not concentrated in a single end-of-project review.
- Sustainable implementation depends on shared vocabulary, safe escalation and visible executive sponsorship as much as on tools.
- Procurement is a critical governance checkpoint for organisations that buy AI rather than build it, and does not remove the buyer's own UK GDPR obligations.
- For agency-supplied operational staff, governance needs to travel with the worker through briefing, portable vetting and a genuine right to escalate.
- Track whether reviews change outcomes, not just how many reviews are completed.

FURTHER READING

- ICO — AI and data protection risk toolkit, ico.org.uk
- NCSC — Guidelines for secure AI system development
- Crown Commercial Service — guidance on AI procurement for public bodies

MODULE 7 CHECK-IN QUIZ

Five questions to confirm your understanding before moving on. Answers are provided in the Answer Key at the end of the course.

1. According to Module 7, where should governance checkpoints ideally be placed in the development lifecycle?

- A. Only at the very end, just before launch
- B. Distributed across each stage of the lifecycle, matched to the decisions made there
- C. Only during data collection
- D. Governance checkpoints are unnecessary if the team is experienced

2. What is identified as a critical, and frequently under-used, governance checkpoint for organisations that buy AI rather than build it?

- A. Marketing review
- B. Procurement
- C. Annual staff appraisals
- D. Office relocation planning

3. Why is “escalation without penalty” important for sustainable AI governance?

- A. It guarantees a project will never be delayed
- B. It gives teams confidence that raising a concern will be treated as diligence rather than an obstacle to be worked around
- C. It removes the need for a named accountable owner
- D. It is a legal requirement under the Equality Act 2010

4. Does using a third-party AI vendor remove a buying organisation's own UK GDPR obligations?

- A. Yes, entirely
- B. No, the buying organisation typically retains its own obligations as a controller or joint controller
- C. Only if the vendor is based outside the UK
- D. Only for high-risk systems

5. What is identified as a common pitfall in measuring governance success?

- A. Measuring the number of reviews completed rather than the outcomes those reviews changed
- B. Measuring outcomes rather than review volume
- C. Involving engineering teams in process design
- D. Distributing checkpoints across the lifecycle